

S.H.F.J. Manekshaw

Field marshal 1914

WARRIOR KING

He planned the campaign, supervised its execution, won India's most famous war and then declined to take full credit. He also stood up to the indomitable Indira Gandhi and her entire Cabinet.

■ By Lt-General Depinder Singh

For Sam Manekshaw being famous and influential was a fitting reward for an eminently successful career and a visible indication of enormous professional merit. In the momentous days of 1971, when the country needed a hero, he was there to lead the Indian Army to a magnificent victory.

Born in 1914 in Amritsar, he did his schooling at Nainital's Sherwood College and Hindu Sabha College in Amritsar. He should have followed two elder brothers to London for higher studies, but his parents felt he was too young to be on his own. Instead, he joined the Indian Military Academy (IMA) and was commissioned in 1934. During the second World War he was in Burma, where while leading a spirited attack, he was seriously wounded and given a battlefield award, the Military Cross.

By 1969, when he was appointed the chief of army staff, he had gathered around himself an aura of greatness. A no-nonsense soldier's soldier, he was seen as a brilliant strategic visionary, compassionate to a fault ("I can never say no", he once remarked, "thank God, I wasn't born a woman") and a man of impeccable character. Always in a hurry, he did not suffer fools, yet was humble

enough to walk across to a subordinate's office with a file to obtain a clarification. Visits to units were meant to advise and correct, never to catch. On one such visit when the commanding officer asked what action was taken against a man who contracted venereal disease and when he was told the man's head was shaved off, he roared, "Shaved off? Dammit, he didn't do it with his head."

A brilliant orator, he was equally gifted with the written word. His drafts and notings were models of clarity, brevity and wit. A note from the Prime Minister's Office alleging nepotism in the army because a certain major general had been appointed director weapons and equipment, elicited a reply even though one was not necessary. "The complaint alleges nepotism in the army," he wrote. "The general officer is a high caste Hindu, I am an equally high caste Parsi. So no religious relationship exists. The general is 46-year-old, I am 52. Therefore, I could not possibly have sired him. So, there is no paternal relationship either."

In social circles, especially diplomatic, he was a guest much in demand. He always cut a dashing figure with his athletic physique, immaculate dress sense and the

charismatic ability to put the other person at ease. At one such 'do', an ambassador's wife seeking to entice him to her party asked whether he liked dancing. "I don't dance very well," he replied, "but I hold well."

His crowning achievement was the remarkable victory of December 1971. There is a saying that victory has many parents and defeat is an orphan. So it was here, and many claimants have sought credit for that victory. The fact of the matter is that it was Manekshaw who planned the campaign, supervised its execution and won it. Who can forget the great moral courage he displayed when he stood up to Indira Gandhi and her entire cabinet who wanted military intervention into East Bengal in May 1971. His lone voice of dissent, stating that he would act only when he was ready, carried the day. Narrating this confrontation later he was to remark that a pretty thin line existed between his elevation to Field Marshal and getting the sack. When Indira Gandhi asked him to take the surrender on 16 December 1971 in Dacca, it was his magnanimity that made him reply that it was lieutenant-general Jagjit Singh's prerogative to do the honours.

The author served as military assistant to the Field Marshal